Although vaguely interesting, this method of generating HTML is fairly laborious and probably isn't used much in practice. Most people write HTML directly, use a templating system, or use an application framework, such as Rails. Unfortunately, we don't have space here to discuss Rails—take a look at the online documentation at http://rubyonrails.org—so let's look at templating.

Using the CGI Class to Handle Cookies

Cookies are a way of letting web applications store their state on the user's machine. Frowned upon by some, cookies are still a convenient (if unreliable) way of remembering session information.

The Ruby CGI class handles the loading and saving of cookies for you. You can access the cookies associated with the current request using the `cookies` method, and you can set cookies back into the browser by setting the `cookie` parameter of `out` to reference either a single cookie or an array of cookies:

web/cookies.rb

```
#!/usr/bin/ruby
require "cgi"

COOKIE_NAME = "chocolate chip"

cgi = CGI.new
values = cgi.cookies[COOKIE_NAME]

msg = if values.empty?
  "It looks as if you haven't visited recently"
else
  "You last visited #{values[0]}"
end

cookie = CGI::Cookie.new(COOKIE_NAME, Time.now.to_s)
cookie.expires = Time.now + 30 * 24 * 3600 # 30 days
cgi.out("cookie" => cookie) { msg }
```

Templating with ERB

Templating systems let you separate the presentation and logic of your application.

So far we've looked at using Ruby to create HTML output, but we can turn the problem inside out: we can actually embed Ruby in an HTML document. The embedded Ruby (or ERB) library is included with Ruby's standard distribution.

Embedding Ruby in HTML is a very powerful concept—it gives us the equivalent of a scripting tool such as PHP, but with the full power of Ruby.

Using ERB

ERB is a filter. Input text is passed through untouched, with the following exceptions:

Expression	Description
<% *ruby code* %>	This executes the Ruby code between the delimiters.
<%= *ruby expression* %>	This evaluates the Ruby expression and replaces the sequence with the expression's value.